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CANNONS & COASTLINES



A Tabletop Naval Conquest Game

RULES OF PLAY

v0.5

IN DEVELOPMENT ·
SUBJECT TO CHANGE

*Rules, factions, and fleet compositions
may shift as we playtest.*

Welcome Aboard

Fair winds and a following sea.

Cannons & Coastlines is a tabletop naval game for 2 to 20 players. Each player commands a small fleet of 3D-printed ships that roll across the table on built-in wheels. The ships fire real, tension-loaded miniature cannons and cannonballs. The game has no dice, board, or grid. Just the ships, the islands between them, and the coins earned from holding those islands.

AT THE TABLE

Players: 2–20 (2–6 Default · 6–20 Group) · **Ages:** 10+ · **Play time:** 30–90 min

HOW IT WORKS

On each turn, every one of the ships in your fleet steers or fires, never both, and then sails forward. A ship touching an island may take an island action instead and hold still. To steer, swivel the ship; to move it, push it along its wheels, which click to count the distance. To fire, plug one of your cannons into a slot on the ship and press down on the firing mechanism until the shot releases. The shot goes straight out from the slot, so you line up your aim **before** the turn you fire.

Each cannonball hit removes one **fitting** (a removable piece off your ship, like masts or cargo) from the target ship. A ship with no fittings left is **dead in the water**: it can no longer move, but it can still fire. The bare hull can absorb **one more hit** after the last fitting is gone; the hit after that sinks the ship.

Islands sit between the fleets. Capture one by planting your flag on it and it will pay out **coins**. Coins can be spent at the start of any turn for one-time effects listed in the Coin Actions section, or hoarded as victory points.

Setup

1. **Build your fleet.** Claim a faction's ships, flags, cannons, and cannonballs. Place your faction card in front of you. (Bonus: Design your own paper flags!)
2. **Place the islands.** Going clockwise, each player sets one island on the table. Keep islands at least **6" apart** and **12" from any table edge**.
3. **Add terrain (optional).** Together, place 2–6 rocks or reefs anywhere on the table. Terrain blocks ships and breaks up firing lanes. You can use household objects for this.
4. **Deploy your fleet.** Claim an edge of the table and line your ships up **touching that edge**, facing inward. (Islanders: use *Home Waters* now to place your starting ship at an island.)
5. **Fill the bag.** Put all coins into the draw bag and shake it to mix.
6. **Begin play.** The youngest player goes first. Play passes clockwise. Choose Default mode (2–6 players) or Group mode (6–20 players).

PLAYERS	ISLANDS
2	4
3–4	6
5–6	8
Group mode (6–20)	10–12

WHAT HAPPENED	RESULT
No fittings left	Dead in the water. No move, can fire, 1 hit left
Dead ship hit again	Scuttled. Gone for good
Hits friendly first	Nothing. Shot is spent.
Ricochets to 2nd ship	Nothing. First contact is the only hit.
Hits terrain	Nothing

CAPTURING THINGS

TARGET	HOW
Dead enemy ship	Touch it + spend Boarding & Repair (same turn). Joins fleet at 1 fitting.
Uncaptured island	Touch it, wait a turn, then Raise Flag.
Undefended enemy island	Touch, wait a turn, swap flag.
Defended enemy island	Clear defenders, then capture as above.

COIN CHEATSHEET

- Brace:** shield next hit.
- Signal:** one ship idles, another acts twice.
- Evasive:** slide one ship-width.
- Gunner:** fire twice.
- Repair:** restore 1 fitting.
- Boarding:** 1 hit at contact.



Your Turn

A turn has two steps, in this order:

1. **Spend coins** you want to use, before any ship moves or fires.
2. **Each of your ships takes its turn.**

Play then passes to the next player.

SPENDING COINS

Coins are not actions. They are spent **at the start of your turn**, before any ship moves or fires. You may spend any number of coins on a single turn. After a coin's effect resolves, return it to the bag.

There is **no hand limit**. You may hold as many coins as you collect.

EACH SHIP

Ships are forever sailing forward. On its turn, each of your ships does two things, in this order:

1. **One action:** Set Heading, Fire, or, if it is touching an island, an Island action.
2. **Click forward** at least once, up to its faction's **Move Count**.

A ship that takes an Island action skips the forward click. No ship both steers and fires on the same turn.

Passing a turn. A  **Signal Flags** coin passes one ship's action to another.

The first only clicks forward; the second takes two full turns, so it may steer on one and fire on the other. The giving ship must be yours and not dead in the water; the receiving ship may be yours or an ally's. One ship may receive more than one transfer, but **Skilled Gunner** still applies to a single turn.

MOVEMENT

One click is one revolution of the ship's movement wheel (see **The Wheel**). Every ship ends its turn by clicking forward along its current heading. You cannot change heading between clicks.

Quick Reference

EACH SHIP: ONE ACTION, THEN CLICK FORWARD

- **A, Set Heading:** Rotate up to 90°. Adds no movement.
- **B, Fire:** Plug cannon into a slot. Press to fire. No rotating.
- **C, Island:** *Pick one:* Raise flag · Collect 1 coin · Fire from island slot.
- **Then click forward** 1 to Move Count. An Island action skips it.

Spend coins at the start of your turn, before ship actions.

CANNON FIRING

1. Pick a ship and a cannon slot (on the ship, or on the island it's touching).
2. Plug the cannon in.
3. Ship cannot Set Heading; aim was set on an earlier turn.
4. Press the mechanism. Fire, then click the ship forward.

Cannons need a crew. Your ship is the crew.

VICTORY POINTS

WHAT YOU HAVE	POINTS
Each surviving ship	3
Each island you hold	2
Each unspent coin	1
Most in any category	+2

Declare Victory at start of turn with ≥ 25 points.

HIT RESOLUTION

WHAT HAPPENED	RESULT
Hits enemy ship	Pull 1 fitting

Designer Notes

CANNON CALIBRATION

The cannons fire by flexing printed plastic under tension, so two copies of the same cannon will rarely shoot with exactly the same force. The firing arm also softens slightly with use. **Fire a few practice rounds at the start of each game** so everyone can calibrate their aim before the first real shot counts.

THE WHEEL

Every ship has a wheel built into the stern. Two details matter:

- Wrap a thin rubber band around the rim before seating the wheel in the hull. The wheel needs the band to click at all; without it, the rim slides on the table instead of rolling.
- The wheel has a **flat spot** on one side. One full revolution brings the flat back to the table, ending one **click** and parking the ship between turns.

PRINT TIPS

- Print everything in **PLA** or **PETG** unless noted. It's rigid enough for the cannon mechanism and cheap enough to replace when pieces wear out.
- Cannonballs can be printed in **TPU**. They weigh about the same but bounce far less, which keeps shots closer to where they land. Coarser layer heights make them shoot harder and less predictably.
- The cannon's flex arm is the part to orient carefully. Lay it so the print layers run **across** the bending direction, not along it. Layer lines parallel to the flex will split under load.
- Print a few spare cannons per player. The snap mechanism loses tension after hundreds of shots. Swapping in a fresh cannon restores the original feel without reprinting the whole fleet.
- Bed leveling is critical. A nozzle too close to the bed may cause pieces like masts not to fit in their slots.

MOVE COUNT	CLICKS PER TURN
2	1–2
3	1–3
4	1–4

Ships cannot pass through other ships, islands, rocks, or reefs. If a ship contacts any of these during a click, it stops there and forfeits any remaining clicks this turn.

Table edges. A ship that has no room to complete its mandatory click stops at the edge and forfeits any remaining clicks. If it would be forced off the table with no room at all, it is **scuttled** and removed. Plan your headings ahead.

ACTION A: SET HEADING

Rotate the ship up to **90°**, port or starboard. It adds **no** movement.

Queen's Fleet, Disciplined Crew. Queen's Fleet ships can swing a full **180°** instead of 90°, once per ship per turn.

ACTION B: FIRE

1. Take one of your cannons.
2. Plug it into any open slot on the firing ship (or, for **Fire from Island** below, on the island your ship is touching).
3. Load a cannonball, then press down on the firing mechanism until the shot fires.
4. Remove the cannon from the slot.

Cannons fire **straight out from the slot**. A ship that fires **does not Set Heading** this turn, so your aim is whatever direction the ship is already pointing. Line up the angle on an earlier turn, then commit to the shot. The shot resolves before the ship clicks forward. The same cannon can be used by more than one ship in a single turn; simply move it from one ship to the next.

Cannons need a crew. Your ship is the crew. To fire any cannon, on a ship or an island, one of your ships must be touching it and spend a Fire action. Held islands cannot fire on their own without a ship in contact.

ACTION C: ISLAND

If your ship is **touching an island**, it may take one of the following actions instead of steering or firing. It then skips its forward click:

- **Raise Flag.** Plant your flag on the island. The island must be empty (or have just been cleared of defenders), and your ship must have been touching the island **at the end of your previous turn**.
- **Collect.** The island must already fly **your flag**. Draw 1 coin from the bag at random.
- **Fire from Island.** The island must already fly your flag. Plug a cannon into one of the island's cannon slots and fire as normal. Islands have cannon coverage in all directions.

Each ship takes at most one island action per turn.

ISLANDS

Each island flies **one flag at a time**.

- **Multiple fleets touching an empty island.** No one may raise a flag until only one fleet's ships remain in contact.
- **Enemy flag on the island.** Drive off all enemy ships first, then capture as normal.
- **Your island, your ships (or a teammate's).** No conflict; the flag stays.
- **Dead-in-the-water ships do not defend.** A dead ship at your island does not block enemy capture. But if an enemy captures and repairs the dead ship, it **does** count as a defender afterward.

The Print List

A **faction set** is one complete print run for one player: their fleet plus a fair share of shared terrain and coins. The only non-printed parts are the draw bag (any small cloth pouch) and the wheel rubber bands. Print at **0.2 or 0.16mm** layer height, **15%** infill. Print the **fit test** first to check that masts, cargo and cannons seat.

PER FACTION SET

PIECE	QUANTITY	NOTES
Ships	2–5	Some ship models may print better with supports enabled.
Masts	1 per ship + 1 per island	Short Masts go on islands and Islander ships. Print spares.
Cargo and barrels	Varies by ship	Enough to fill your ships' fitting slots.
Sails	1 per mast	Decorate to customize your fleet.
Cannons	3–4	One works, but spares help when one wears out.
Cannonballs	10	TPU with three walls and no infill bounces less.
Movement wheel	1 per ship	Rubber band over the rim. Hard to remove once in.
Islands	2–3	Print Islands , or put Island Toppers on household objects.
Rocks / Reefs	2-4	Optional terrain. Block movement and cannonballs.
Coins	1 set of 20	Each set is 4 Brace, 2 Signal, 2 Evasive, 4 Gunner, 4 Repair, 4 Boarding.

IMAGE	PIECE	COLOR
	Cannon. The tension-loaded firing mechanism. Plugs into cannon slots.	Black, gunmetal grey, or custom
	Cannonball. Loaded into the cannon and fired across the table. EASY TO LOSE	A bright color like neon green or orange for easy recovery. TPU optional for less bounce.
	Movement Wheel. Insert into the slot in the bottom of the hull. One full revolution is one click of movement.	Any color. Wrap a thin rubber band around the rim before assembly.
	Island. A freestanding island with cannon slots and a hole for a short mast to fly your flag. Needs nothing under it.	Green, sand, or grey; Terrain colors.
	Island Topper. A small puck with cannon slots and flag holes. Turns any household object into an island.	Sand, grey, or green; Terrain colors.
	Coins (x6 types). Drawn from the bag and spent at the start of your turn for one-time effects.	Gold

Combat

When a cannonball hits an enemy ship, remove one **fitting** (masts or cargo) from the ship and set it in the water beside the ship. No friendly fire.

- **Ship has no fittings left.** It is **Dead in the Water**. It cannot move, so it skips its forward click, but it can still fire. The bare hull can still take **one more hit** before sinking.
- **Hit on a dead-in-the-water ship.** The ship is **Scuttled** and removed.
- **Ricochets.** The first ship the cannonball touches takes the hit. Any further contact (deflections, rolling onto a second hull) does no damage. If the first ship it touches is friendly, the shot is spent and damages nothing.
- **Missed shots.** Retrieve missed cannonballs at the end of your turn.

Total hits to sink = Fittings + 1. A ship with 3 fittings absorbs 3 hits to remove its fittings (leaving it dead in the water), then sinks on the 4th.

BOARDING

While your ship is **touching** an active enemy ship, you may spend  **Boarding Party** to remove 1 fitting from that enemy ship.

CAPTURING A DEAD ENEMY SHIP

While your ship is touching a dead-in-the-water enemy ship, spend **both** 

Boarding Party and  **Repair Crew** on the same turn. Restore **1 fitting** under your own flag. The captured ship becomes part of your fleet and may act on the following turn.

SCUTTling

A dead-in-the-water ship sinks on the next hit it takes. You may scuttle one of your **own** dead ships to prevent an enemy from capturing it.

REPAIRING

Spend  **Repair Crew** to restore 1 fitting to one of your ships.

- If the ship **still has fittings**, the repair can be made from any distance.
- If the ship is **dead in the water**, another of your ships must touch it to repair.

Coin Actions

COIN	WHAT IT DOES
	Brace for Impact Place the coin in a ship's coin slot. The next hit that ship takes is negated (no fitting lost) and the coin returns to the bag.
	Signal Flags One of your ships gives up its action; another ship takes two full turns instead of one.
	Evasive Maneuvers One of your ships slides exactly one ship-width sideways (port or starboard) without rotating. The slide is on top of that ship's turn.
	Skilled Gunner One of your ships fires twice this turn. You may move the cannon between shots. Both resolve before it clicks forward.
	Repair Crew Restore 1 fitting to one of your ships. Required to capture a dead-in-the-water enemy ship.
	Boarding Party While touching an enemy ship, remove 1 fitting from it. Required to capture a dead-in-the-water enemy ship.

Each player contributes 20 coins to the bag at setup: 4 Brace · 2 Signal · 2 Evasive · 4 Gunner · 4 Repair · 4 Boarding.

The Parts

Every printed piece in the base set, with what it does and recommended print color. Faction ships and fittings vary in shape; flag or alliance color always wins if you'd rather match.

IMAGE	PIECE	COLOR
	Ship. The hull, with a wheel built into the stern and cannon slots along the deck. Each faction has its own ship model.	Faction or alliance color. Queen's Fleet ships shown in blue-grey ; Corsairs in black .
	Mast. A removable fitting that plugs into the deck, with the flag holder built into the top: slide a paper flag of any design into the slot. Print horizontally.	Wood/Brown or Black
	Short Mast. The same mast, shorter. Used on islands and on Islander catamarans.	Same as your masts
	Cargo & Barrel. Removable fittings : a chest of supplies, or a barrel. Either one fills a cargo slot.	Wood/Brown. Any natural wood tone reads correctly.
	Sail. Slides over the mast. Cosmetic, decorate and modify as you desire.	White, black, or custom
	Damaged Sail. Torn sail variant.	White, black, or custom

The Seven Factions

Queen's Fleet and **Corsairs** come in the base game. The other five are expansion packs. The **Faction Reference Cards** have the full stats; these are just quick sketches of how each one plays.

QUEEN'S FLEET

A good pick for a first game.

Disciplined Crew: swings **180°** instead of 90°, so maneuvering mistakes are easy to walk back.

CORSAIRS

Faster and more numerous than the Queen's Fleet, with thinner hulls.

Plunder: an **extra coin** on every successful board or capture, so their economy rewards picking fights.

TREASURE FLEET

Only two ships on the table, but every island they hold pays double.

Bountiful Harvest: **2 coins** per collect instead of 1, so even a small holding funds big plays.

STONE FLEET

Slow to cross the table, but punishing to chip at.

Stone Hulls: **ignores the first hit** each turn. One big salvo works; pecking at them doesn't.

SHADOW FLEET

Average across every stat, with one trick that changes the math.

Return from the Deep: sunken ships come back on a coin spend, so trading hulls isn't as final as it looks.

THE INDUSTRY

Two cannon slots per ship: a **forward-facing** bow gun and a rotating turret that can fire any direction.

Rotating Turret: the second slot sits in a **turret fitting** that swivels. Like any fitting, the turret can be shot off; if that happens, only the bow slot remains until it's repaired.

THE ISLANDERS

Fast, numerous, and each one folds to a **single hit**. Played well, the numbers make up for the paper hulls.

Home Waters: a free starting island.

Winning

The game ends in one of three ways:

- **Last fleet afloat.** Only one player still has ships on the table. That player wins.
- **Declared victory.** At the start of your turn, declare victory if you believe you have **25 or more points**. Tally all players' scores. If yours is still at least 25 and is higher than or tied with the next-highest, you win.
- **Stalemate.** Every island is under a flag and no island changed hands during the previous two rounds. Proceed to scoring. (optional)

SCORING

WHAT YOU HAVE	POINTS
Each surviving ship	3
Each island you hold	2
Each unspent coin	1
<i>Bonus:</i> most ships	+2
<i>Bonus:</i> most islands	+2
<i>Bonus:</i> most coins	+2

Ties on bonuses: every tied player receives the full +2. Highest total wins. In Fleet play, score the fleet as a single player.

Example. A player with 1 ship, 3 islands, and 12 coins (earning both the most-islands and most-coins bonuses) scores $3 + 6 + 12 + 2 + 2 = 25$. An opponent with 3 ships, 2 islands, and 4 coins (earning the most-ships bonus) scores $9 + 4 + 4 + 2 = 19$. The first player wins.

Alternate Modes

Three optional modes layer on top of the standard 2–6 player game: **Group Mode** for parties, **Fleets & Alliances** for cooperative or shifting-loyalty play, and **Custom Armada** for large mixed-faction battles.

GROUP MODE (6–20 PLAYERS)

All players act simultaneously. Play alternates between two phases, each on a **60–90 second timer**:

- **Movement phase.** Spend **Evasive Maneuvers**, then every ship away from an island sets heading or holds it, and clicks forward.
- **Action phase.** Spend action coins (**Brace, Gunner, Repair, Boarding, Signal Flags**), then every ship that held its heading may Fire, and every ship at an island may take an Island action. A **Signal Flags** transfer passes one ship's Fire to another, even if that ship set heading.

Choose one player as the **moderator**. They announce phases, run the timer, and resolve disputes. Group mode is intentionally more chaotic than the standard game.

FLEETS & ALLIANCES

Fleets (team play). Two or more players share a single fleet. Each commands one ship and resolves their action simultaneously on the fleet's turn. Coins and the faction passive belong to the fleet, so agree on spends together. Turn order alternates by fleet. Example: six players, two three-player Queen's Fleet sides.

Alliances. For free-for-all games. Players form or break informal pacts at any time, updating flag colors when allegiances shift.

Trading. Any two players may **freely trade coins, ships, and islands** at any time, regardless of alliance. Trades can grease a new pact, buy a turn of safety, or just keep things moving.

Watch for at the table.

- **Crippled-ship leverage.** Near-sunk players trade alliances for **Repair** coins or covering fire, sometimes flipping the game in a turn.
- **Bluffed shots.** Aim is visible a turn early; line up a shot you never fire and watch opponents divert.

- **Sacrificial hulls.** A dead-in-the-water ship still fires and blocks. Park a damaged ship in a chokepoint and it becomes a battle arena. Opponents pile in to capture or scuttle.

CUSTOM ARMADA

Contributed by Joshua David

A large-scale variant for advanced games. Each player fields a mixed armada of up to **15 ships** drawn from any factions, trading coordination for sheer presence.

Build your armada.

- Up to **15 ships** per player. No more than half may belong to a single faction.
- Use only the **printed values** (movement, cannon slots, fittings). All faction abilities are ignored.
- Recommended size by table: 4×4 ft → 4–6 ships, 5×5 ft → 6–9, 6×6 ft → 8–12, 6×8 ft or larger → 10–15.

Coin cap. An armada may hold at most **20 coins**. Any earned beyond that go straight back to the bag.

Restricted actions. Coordinating a large mixed fleet is hard:

- Only **3 ships** may **Set Heading** each turn. The rest hold their heading.
- Every ship still clicks forward. Any number of ships may **Fire** or take **Island actions**.

Squadrons (optional). Divide the armada into 2–3 Squadrons of 3–6 ships each. Each Squadron picks a **Squadron Flagship**; the whole armada also picks a single **Fleet Flagship**. Fleet Flagship effects apply armada-wide. Squadron Flagship effects apply only within their Squadron.

Command Shock. If a Flagship is sunk, the affected force loses control.

- **Fleet Flagship sunk.** The entire armada suffers shock. Remove your flags from every island you hold (they become neutral). Move every ship currently touching an island within **6"** of your table edge, facing inward. Take no actions and spend no coins for one full turn; your ships only click forward. Then designate a new Fleet Flagship and resume.
- **Squadron Flagship sunk.** Only that Squadron suffers shock, with the same effects limited to its ships and islands. Designate a new Squadron Flagship after.

Scoring. Standard scoring applies, except **surviving ships are worth 0 VP**. The **most ships** bonus still counts. An armada wins on islands and coins.